Merve Demirel

Updated October 14, 2026

Institute for International Economic Studies
Stockholm University
SE-106 91 Stockholm, Sweden

Email: merve.demirel@iies.su.se
Website: demirelmerve.com
Phone: +46 76 053 24 79
Citizenship: Turkey
Residence: Sweden (permanent)

Education

2020–2027 **Stockholm University (IIES)**, PhD in Economics (expected June 2027)
2024–2025 **Columbia University**, Visiting Scholar, hosted by Laura Boudreau
2017–2019 **Stockholm School of Economics**, MSc in Economics
2012–2017 **Koç University**, BA in Economics, BA in Business

References

Johannes Haushofer
Cornell University
haushofer@cornell.edu

Anna Tompsett
Stockholm University
anna.tompsett@iies.su.se

Tessa Bold
Stockholm University
tessa.bold@iies.su.se

Laia Navarro-Sola
Stockholm University
laia.navarrosola@iies.su.se

Research Fields

Development Economics, Labor Economics, Gender

Job Market Paper

Migration Costs and Higher Education: Experimental Evidence from India

Migration in developing countries is low despite large income differences across space. This paper asks whether the non-pecuniary costs of migration hold prospective college students back, and whether access to a migrant peer can reduce them. I run a randomized controlled trial with 1,682 final-year secondary students across 52 schools in Maharashtra, India, offering half a phone-based mentorship program that pairs each student with a university student who migrated for college. At baseline, the average student would forgo a 129% increase in expected post-graduation earnings rather than study away from home, a penalty that rises steeply with distance, and beliefs about the difficulty of moving, safety, parental approval, and happiness account for a substantial amount of it. Mentorship shifts choices: applications and moves away from home increase, a pre-specified migration index rises by 0.16 standard deviations, and the effect is concentrated among short-distance moves made by men. Non-pecuniary beliefs about the distant cities do not improve.
Pre-registered: AEARCTR-0016735.

Working Papers

Distance, Gender, and Access to Elite Higher Education: Evidence from India's Centralized Engineering Admissions (with Xuanzhe Hou and Yash Kanoria)
Earlier version circulated as "How Far Would You Go? Higher Education and Migration Decisions in India."

Identity and Human Capital Investment: Evidence from the Veiling Ban Removal in Turkey (with Avenia Ghazarian)
HoSS Working Paper 2026-1, Stockholm School of Economics.

Moving to Opportunity Abroad: The Effects of International Educational Migration (with Toman Barsbai, Philipp Moskopp, Marcello Perez-Alvarez and Matthias Sutter)
World Bank Social Policy and Labor Discussion Paper No. 2702. Pre-registered: AEARCTR-0012924.

Educational Migration Prospects and Human Capital Investments: Evidence from a Uganda-Germany College Access Program (with Toman Barsbai, Philipp Moskopp, Marcello Perez-Alvarez and Matthias Sutter)
World Bank Social Policy and Labor Discussion Paper No. 2702. Pre-registered: AEARCTR-0009992.

Work in Progress

International Migration and Identity Formation: The Perception of the Self and Others (with Toman Barsbai, Philipp Moskopp, Marcello Perez-Alvarez and Matthias Sutter)
Pre-registered: AEARCTR-0016846.

Harassment in Colleges: A Bottom-Up Approach (with Eugenia Frezza, Emmanuel Keith Kisaame and Arne Nasgowitz)
Pilot stage.

Research Grants

2026 **Max Planck Society** (EUR 147,480); **ECONtribute** (EUR 19,850); **Leading House Africa**, Swiss Tropical and Public Health Institute (CHF 13,625)

2025 **J-PAL**, Jobs and Opportunity Initiative / Social Protection Initiative (USD 250,000); **ECONtribute** (EUR 60,000); **J-PAL**, Crime and Violence Initiative, Exploratory Research and Travel Grant (USD 9,995)

2024 **Royal Swedish Academy of Sciences** (SEK 298,500); **The Weiss Fund**, Travel and Piloting Grant (USD 14,938); **Mannerfelt Foundation** (SEK 38,700); **Stockholm Center for Global Asia** (SEK 15,000); **SurveyCTO**, Primary Data Collection Research Grant

2023 **World Bank**, Innovation Challenge on Jobs and Migration (USD 279,900); **ECONtribute** (EUR 50,000); **PEDL**, Exploratory Research Grant (GBP 5,000); **Mannerfelt Foundation** (SEK 30,000); **IIES** (SEK 20,000)

2022 **ECONtribute** (EUR 99,712)

Fellowships and Honors

2021 **Jan Wallander and Tom Hedelius Foundation** (SEK 500,000)

2018 **Stockholms Grosshandlarsocietetet**, Scholarship for Studies Abroad (SEK 15,000)

2017 **Af Jochnik Foundation**, MSc Scholarship (SEK 300,000)

2016 **European Bank for Reconstruction and Development**, Starting Grant

2012 **Koç University**, Full Merit Scholarship

Teaching Experience

2021 **Stockholm University**, Introductory Microeconomics, TA to Lars Vahtrik

2019 **Stockholm School of Economics**, Introductory Microeconomics, TA to Richard Friberg

2018 **Stockholm School of Economics**, International Economics, TA to Paul Segerström

Research Experience

2018–2020 **Stockholm School of Economics**, Research Assistant for Martina Björkman-Nyqvist, Abhijeet Singh and Pamela Campa

2018 **Stockholm University**, Research Assistant for Anna Tompsett

Talks and Conferences ([†]scheduled; [*]co-author)

2026 Oxford Development Economics Workshop; RFBerlin Migration Forum; Women in Economics Network Conference; ASWEDE Conference[†]; Talent Economics Conference[†]; The Economics of Migration Junior Webinar[†]

2025 Tilburg University; University of Groningen; Development Colloquium, Columbia University; Interdisciplinary PhD Workshop in Sustainable Development, Columbia University; SEEDEC, Max Planck Institute Bonn; Workshop on Gender and Economics, Luxembourg[*]; Development Economics Meeting, Erlangen[*]

2024 ASWEDE Conference

2023 European Network Development Conference; ASWEDE Conference

2022 ASWEDE Conference

Refereeing

Journals: *Science*, *Journal of Population Economics*

Service

2020–2023 **Women in Economics Initiative**, Board Member

Other Experience

2016–2017 **Jana Impact**, Co-founder of a social enterprise for refugee employment

2016–2017 **Carma Consultancy**, Business Development Intern

Languages

Turkish (native), English (fluent), Swedish (intermediate), French (beginner)